Lesson 38 material: Avoiding Plagiarism and Formatting Your Paper

4.8: Avoiding Plagiarism

From *Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text* by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0). This section: CC BY-NC 4.0.
Original page, with audio and online exercises:
https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Reading_Writing_Research_and_Reasoning%3A_An_Advanced_ESL_Text/04%3A_In
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

What is plagiarism?

Plagiarism is a kind of academic dishonesty. Colleges and universities take plagiarism seriously; many discipline or even expel students who are found to be plagiarizing.

Plagiarism happens when we use another person's intellectual materials and don't give them credit. We can even plagiarize from ourselves if we re-use our own work without acknowledging that it has appeared elsewhere.

Many educators used to believe that students plagiarized either because they were lazy or because they just didn't care about anything but getting that final piece of paper: the degree or certificate. Both of these reasons are still true sometimes, but today instructors know that plagiarism and cheating are often motivated by more complicated factors. For example, sometimes students just don't realize that they are plagiarizing. However, unintentional plagiarism is still considered plagiarism, so it's important to know how to avoid making this mistake.

The attitudes about plagiarism in the United States may be new to you. In some cultures, to use the words of others is a sign of honor and respect. In your country, the ownership of words may not be as important as it is in the U.S., where high value is given to using your own words. As a result, some actions that are considered "plagiarism" in the U.S. may be acceptable in your country. Even though your instructors here may understand and respect your culture, they will probably judge your work by American standards so it is important to understand what counts as plagiarism in the United States.

Recognizing plagiarism

Let's see if you can recognize if something is plagiarism.

Try this!

Which of the following scenarios show plagiarism? (Remember, even if it's unintentional, it's still plagiarism!)

1. A student finds a great quotation to use in her essay but forgets to indicate where it's from.
2. Three students in a study group turn in the same answers for a set of exercises.
3. Three students in a study group help each other understand the concepts in the unit, but they each turn in their own answers.
4. A student doesn't realize an important assignment is due in class the next day. Fortunately, they completed a similar assignment in a different class last semester, so they turn that one in instead.

(To see answers, check 4.12: Integrating Evidence Answer Key)

Avoiding plagiarism

So, how can you avoid plagiarism? Here are some strategies.

1. Take notes carefully. If you add source material to your work, mark it or identify it in such a way that you will *know* it's from a source. Cite the work immediately and add it to your Works Cited list.
2. And, if you use someone else's intellectual property, you must give them credit. If you bring their work into your assignment, you must mention them as the work's owners using in-text citations.
3. If you are unsure about whether or not something is acceptable, check with your instructor! For example, it may be acceptable (and even encouraged!) to use sources from your research in another class or to work with other students in class to get a handle on a complicated concept but, if you have any doubts, it's important to check with your instructor.

Noticing where ideas come from

Let's see if you can identify which ideas come from a student and which come from outside sources.

Notice this!

Read the following example paragraph. Can you tell which ideas are the student's own and which are from outside sources? How can you tell?

Being able to speak more than one language opens up more employment opportunities. With more and more immigrants coming into the country, more employers are looking for those who can better communicate with people who's best language isn't English. In an *NBC News* article, it was reported that in "2010, there were roughly 240,000 job postings aimed at bilingual workers. But by 2015, that figure swelled to about 630,000... bilingual workers were in demand for both low and high-skilled positions such as financial managers, editors, and industrial engineers" (Cusido). These figures show that there is a desire for those who are able to speak more than one language in a wide range of job markets and these opportunities will likely continue to increase in the future. While speaking multiple languages may not be the only criteria in getting a job, it definitely will help. As Marco Lopez, an executive at a Chicago marketing agency explains, applicants who are bilingual have advantages in being hired (qtd. in Cusido). This shows how simply maintaining connections to an immigrant family's roots and origins can become a major benefit for the children of immigrants. Immigrant parents should be made aware of this benefit so they can foster language growth.

In the example, it is easy to tell whose ideas belong to whom. This is because the paragraph contains clear citations. To properly cite outside sources in your writing, you must do the following:

- Mention the source's owner/creator in your written work at the point where the source is used. You can do this by including the author's name in a sentence or with a parenthetical citation—putting the author's last name in parentheses at the end of the sentence.
- Create a list of all of the sources you used in your assignment; you'll do this by arranging them in a Works Cited list at the end of your essay.

Paraphrasing vs. patchwriting

You will often paraphrase or summarize other sources when you write an academic paper. Paraphrasing means to rewrite someone else's idea in your own words and sentence structure. However, sometimes writers try to paraphrases but do not change the vocabulary and sentence structure enough. This is called "patchwriting." Patchwriting is considered plagiarism, even if the writer cites the source and did not intend to plagiarize.

Identifying paraphrasing and patchwriting

Let's compare a paraphrase and patchwriting of a quotation.

Notice this!

Here is a quotation from an article:

"Around the world, more than half of people—estimates vary from 60 to 75 per cent—speak at least two languages. Many countries have more than one official national languages—South Africa has 11. People are increasingly expected to speak, read and write at least one of a handful of "super" languages, such as English, Chinese, Hindi, Spanish or Arabic, as well. So to be monolingual, as many native English speakers are, is to be in the minority, and perhaps to be missing out" (Vince).

Here is patchwriting:

All over the world, over 50% of people speak at least two languages. Many nations have more than one official national language. For example, South Africa has 11. People increasingly need to speak, read and write at least one of a handful of common languages, such as Spanish, English, Chinese, Hindi, or Arabic, in addition. So people who speak one language, as many native English speakers do, means that you are in the minority and missing out (Vince).

As you can see, some words have been replaced by synonyms. However, about half of the words are the same and the sentence structure is exactly the same. Here, words that are repeated from the original are in bold and square brackets:

All over **[the world,]** over 50% of people speak multiple **[languages. Many]** nations **[have more than one official national language.]** For example, [**South Africa has 11. People increasingly]** need to [**speak, read and write at least one of a handful of]** common [**languages, such as Spanish, English, Chinese, Hindi, or Arabic,]** in addition. **[So]** people who speak one language, **[as many native English speakers]** do, means that you are **[in the minority and missing out]** (Vince).

Here is a paraphrase of the same quotation. You will see that there are not only differences in vocabulary, but also in sentence structure.

According to Gaia Vince, while English speakers often speak only one language, it is actually more common to be multilingual. Speakers of smaller languages often need to learn a major language like English, Spanish, or Chinese, and in addition some countries have multiple official languages.

Now, let's see if you can decide if something is paraphrasing or patchwriting.

Try this!

Here is another quotation:

"Multilingualism has been shown to have many social, psychological and lifestyle advantages. Moreover, researchers are finding a swathe of health benefits from speaking more than one language, including faster stroke recovery and delayed onset of dementia" (Vince).

Is this an appropriate paraphrase, or is it a plagiarism?

Speaking more than one language has many social, psychological, and lifestyle benefits. In addition, researchers find a lot of health benefits from being multilingual. Those include recovering from strokes and dementia developing later (Vince).

(To see the answer, check 4.12: Integrating Evidence Answer Key)

Checking for plagiarism

Now, let's apply this to your own writing.

Apply this!

Look at a draft of your writing or a classmate's writing that uses outside sources.

- Is it clear whose ideas belong to whom?
- Is each outside source in your assignment cited according to the guidelines given by your instructor? If you're not sure, ask your instructor.
- Do you have a list of your Works Cited at the end of your assignment?

Works Cited

Cusido, Carmen. "Report: Want the Job? Be Able to Say So in More than One Language." *NBCNews.com*, NBCUniversal News Group, 13 Mar. 2017.

Vince, Gaia. "Why Being Bilingual Helps Keep Your Brain Fit." *Mosaic*, Aug. 2016, mosaicscience.com/bilingual-brains/.

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Paragraph on cultural differences in plagiarism in "What is Plagiarism" is adapted from Excelsior Owl's page "Plagiarism is Serious." License: CC BY.

Sample sentences are from "Why Being Bilingual Helps Keep Your Brain Fit" published on Mosaic . License: CC BY.

Links on the original page

- The Word on College Reading and Writing: https://openoregon.pressbooks.pub/wrd

4.9: Formatting Your Paper

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Original page, with audio and online exercises:
https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Reading_Writing_Research_and_Reasoning%3A_An_Advanced_ESL_Text/04%3A_In
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Why do we want a standard format?

When you go to a job interview, what do you wear? Most people try to dress professionally (see figure 4.9.1) to make a good first impression because sometimes people make judgments based on outside appearances instead of content. When you send your essay out to be read by other people, you probably also want it to make a good first impression on your readers. You want them to think that your essay is professional and academic, even before they read a single word.

(Picture: Man wearing a suit at a job interview)

Figure: Man wearing a suit at a job interview. ("Man on a Job Interview" by amtec_photos is licensed under CC BY-SA 2.0)

When you write papers for a college course, the instructor will usually require you to use a specific format. Format is a standard way that a paper is required to look. It includes things like the heading, the font, and the punctuation of the list of sources and the in-text citations. There are several different official formats that look different but serve the same purposes. The format makes the paper easy to read, and makes your information about your sources easy for the reader to find.

When you glance at the two papers in figure 4.9.2, which do you think uses an official format? What differences can you find?

(Picture: two pages of typed writing side by side, messy format on the left, neat format on the right)

Figure: "Format comparison" by Gabriel Winer is licensed under CC BY NC.

The two official formats that you will probably need to use in your college courses are MLA format and APA format. The initials stand for the organization that has established the format.

“MLA” stands for *Modern Language Association*. MLA format is international, and is used for academic papers and journals in the areas of language, literature and the humanities. For college English classes, you will be required to use MLA format.

“APA” stands for *American Psychological Association*. APA format is used for academic papers and journals in the social sciences. For many college papers other than English papers, you will be required to use APA format.

MLA format

Setting up a document in MLA format

The following are the basic guidelines for setting up an MLA-formatted document. Your word program will have menu controls to help you with these settings.

- Set margins to 1” on left, right, top, and bottom.
- Set margins to ½” for header and footer.
- Use a standard 12-point font throughout the document. Times New Roman is the most common.
- Double-space throughout the document. Also remove extra space between paragraphs (Microsoft Word defaults to putting in an extra space).
- Use a straight left edge and a “ragged” right edge.
- Indent paragraphs ½” (1 tab).
- Center a document title on page 1. Use plain 12-point font—do not bold, underline, or italicize.
- Create an upper left heading on page 1 only. This should include the following:
  - Your name (first and last name)
  - The teacher’s name
  - The name of the class
  - The date
- Create an upper right header for all pages. This should include the following:
  - Your last name
  - An automatic page number

Sample essay in MLA format

The link below opens a version of a sample essay formatted in MLA 8th edition:

Sample Student Research Paper Heritage Languages.pdf

Creating an MLA Works Cited page

The purpose of the Works Cited page is to collect all of the sources used in a text and to arrange them so they are easy for your reader to locate. Listing the sources also helps you track them and makes it less likely that you might accidentally plagiarize by forgetting to mention a piece of source material.

Setting up the page

Follow these guidelines to set up your Works Cited.

- Works Cited is located at the end of a paper. Always start it at the top of a new page.
- Put the title Works Cited at the top of the page, centered.
- The Works Cited page uses the same formatting as the rest of the paper: 12 point standard font, double spacing, 1" margins on all sides, etc.
- List sources alphabetically, according to whatever comes first in each citation. (Do not list them in the order they occur within the paper.)
- Use "hanging" paragraphs to set up sources. This means that the first line of each source begins at the left margin, while second and subsequent lines are indented by ½" (1 tab). This is the reverse of a regular paragraph. The "hanging" format makes it easy to visually scroll down the list and see each source. If you are using Microsoft Word, you can set hanging paragraphs by choosing the "hanging" setting in the "Paragraphs" menu.

Figure 4.9.2 shows an annotated example of a Works Cited page (Annotated-Works-Cited-Examples to open in a new page):

(Picture: Works Cited page with annotations for different source types)

Figure: Annotated example of a works cited page by Carol Burnell, Jaime Wood, Monique Babin, Susan Pesznecker, and Nicole Rosevear is licensed CC BY NC.

Creating entries on the Works Cited page

Let's look at how to set up Works Cited citations.

We'll work with this article from the *International Online Journal of Primary Education*: "A Longitudinal Study: Emergent Bilinguals' Heritage Language Use and Learning over Time." Figure 4.9.3 shows the top of the first page of this article.

(Picture: screen capture of journal article; shows the source information, but all information is also included below.)

Figure: "Screenshot of online article" by Gabriel Winer is licensed under CC BY NC. Article by Chaehyun Lee is licensed under CC BY 4.0.

Here is the raw information at the top of the article. You will need most of this information for your citation, but not all of it, and not in this order.

- International Online Journal of Primary Education
- 2021, volume 10, issue 1
- Copyright © International Online Journal of Primary Education
- A Longitudinal Study: Emergent Bilinguals' Heritage Language Use and Learning over Time
- Chaehyun Lee
- Ph.D., Assistant Professor, Southeastern Oklahoma State University Department of Educational Instruction and Leadership, United States
- ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-4670-4519clee@se.edu
- Received: March 02, 2021
- Accepted: April 15, 2021
- Published: June 30, 2021

To make a citation, find each piece of information from the source. If certain parts are not there, we simply leave them blank. Note that each item is followed with specific punctuation. Copy these as you create your own citations.

Source information types and formatting rules

Table 4.9.1 shows the types of source information you need to make a citation, an explanation of what each type is, and the special rules for how to capitalize and punctuate that item.

Table 4.9.1: Source information items for Works Cited entries

Type of information	Explanation	Formatting rules	Example			
Author(s)	Person or organization who wrote the text	The first author's name is always reversed, with a comma after the last name: Last Name, First Name.	It is followed by a period.	If there are two authors, list them as Last Name, First Name and First Name Last Name.	If there are three or more authors, list them as First Name et al. (Et al. is Latin for "and more.")	Lee, Chaehyun.

Title	Name of the text	Capitalize all words in the title of the source except for articles, conjunctions, and prepositions.	If it is an article, essay, chapter, or any other “small” piece of material, it will be in quotation marks and plain font.	If it is a book, film, periodical, or an entire web page, it will be in *italic* font with no quotation marks.	The title of the source is followed with a period—and when quotation marks are used, note that the period always goes inside the quotation marks.	"A Longitudinal Study: Emergent Bilinguals' Heritage Language Use and Learning over Time."		
Container	The container is the “place” that holds or houses the source you’re using.	A book chapter (title) is held within a book (container).	A newspaper article (title) is held within a newspaper (container).	An essay on a web page (title) is held within a website (container).	A magazine article (title) is held within a magazine (container).	Capitalize all words in the title of the source except for articles, conjunctions, and prepositions.	The container is almost always in *italic* font and followed by a comma.	*International Online Journal of Primary Education,*
Other contributors	This line provides a way to mention people who assisted with creating or handling the source, e.g., directors, translators, performers, illustrators, etc.	List them using plain, unabbreviated language, e.g., performed by, directed by, etc.	Other contributors are listed in plain font and followed by a comma.	[This article has no other contributors. You can just skip this part.]				
Version	Use this if you want to mention an edition number (e.g., Second Edition, Evening Edition, etc.) or if you want to list a volume (Volume 3), a month (January), etc.	Version is written in plain font and followed by a comma.	"Volume" is abbreviated "vol." and not capitalized.	vol. 1,				

Number	Use this to provide an issue number (e.g., for a magazine or journal), a special archive number (e.g., with museum pieces), or something similar.	Number is written in plain font, not capitalized, and followed by a comma.	Number is abbreviated "no."	no. 10,							
Publisher	The publisher is the person or institution that makes the source available to the world.	Publishers for books, periodicals, and printed materials are usually written on one of the first pages.	Web page publishers can usually be found at the page bottom. If you cannot find the publisher quickly, you might use Google to search for it, i.e., searching 'New York Times Publisher.'	Film and music publishers will usually be located on the material.	Write out the complete publisher name; capitalize it fully and don't abbreviate or omit words.	The publisher is in plain font and followed by a comma.	[Like many online sources, the container and the publisher are the same; there isn't a separate publisher, so you can just skip this part.]				
Publication date	The date the text was published.	Use MLA date format: day month year	Follow the date with a comma.	With longer months, you may abbreviate the source; if you do, follow the abbreviation with a period.	30 June 2021,						
Location	The source's location tells the reader where to find the source. Many sources will not have a location, but it should be listed if present.	If using a book, the page number is the location.	For single pages, use this format: p. 6.	For two or more pages, list like this: pp. 62-4 or pp. 184-96.	If using two or more pages and they cross a "hundred" marker, list like this: pp. 456-502.	With web pages, give the URL—but omit the http:// at the beginning.	If a doi (digital object indicator) number is available, use that instead of a URL.	Do not break URLs or doi's manually to try and fit them into your Works Cited: just type them in and let your Word processor decide where to break them.	If you have a different kind of source and believe you have a location with it, share it as best you can, following these guidelines.	Locations are in plain font and followed by a period.	pp. 1-18, www.iojp

Now, to create a Works Cited citation, link all of the available elements together, following the correct punctuation and placing a space between each component.

- Use your word program's menus or the little arrows on the ruler at the top to set hanging paragraphs.
- Don't break your lines manually: set hanging paragraphs and then keep typing, allowing the software to determine the line breaks.
- Your citation should always end with a period.

Complete citation:

Lee, Chaehyun. "A Longitudinal Study: Emergent Bilinguals' Heritage Language Use and Learning over Time." *International Online Journal of Primary Education*, vol. 10, no. 1, 30 June 2021, pp. 1-18, www.iojpe.org/index.php/iojpe/article/view/1/4.

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Lee, Chaehyun. "A Longitudinal Study: Emergent Bilinguals' Heritage Language Use and Learning over Time." *International Online Journal of Primary Education*, vol. 10, no. 1, 30 June 2021, pp. 1-18. Licensed under CC BY.

Links on the original page

- International Online Journal of Primary Education: http://www.iojpe.org/index.php/iojpe/index
- A Longitudinal Study: Emergent Bilinguals' Heritage Language Use and Learning over Time: http://www.iojpe.org/index.php/iojpe/article/view/1
- Article by Chaehyun Lee: http://www.iojpe.org/index.php/iojpe/article/view/1/4
- Web page (orcid.org): https://orcid.org/0000-0002-4670-4519clee@se.edu
- The Word on College Reading and Writing: https://openoregon.pressbooks.pub/wrd

Attached: Sample Student Research Paper Heritage Languages

A long document (1,497 words), not printed here. Open it from the original page above or from your computer's attachments folder (file: Sample_Student_Research_Paper_Heritage_Languages.pdf). Your tutor has its full text.

Attached: Annotated-Works-Cited-Examples

Page 1: Works Cited Akanegbu, Anuli. "50 Striking Statistics about Distance Education in Higher Education." EDTech, CDW, 12 July 2012, www.edtechmagazine.com/higher/article/2012/07/50- striking-statistics-about-distance-learning-higher-education. Akanegbu, Anuli.(<author) "50 Striking Statistics about Distance Education in Higher Education." (<title of source) EDTech, (<title of container, in italics) CDW, (<title of publisher) 12 July 2012, (<date of source) www.edtechmagazine.com/higher/article/2012/07/50-striking-statistics-about-distance- learning-higher-education. (<location) Disconnected: A Documentary. Directed by Melody Gilbert, performance by Mitchell Lundin, Caitlin Magnusson, and Andrew Tatge, Carleton College, MN, 2008, www.snagfilms.com/films/title/disconnected . Disconnected: A Documentary.(<title of container, in italics) Directed by Melody Gilbert,(<other contributors) performance by Mitchell Lundin, Caitlin Magnusson, and Andrew Tatge,(<other contributors) Carleton College,(<title of publisher/producer) 2008, (<date of source) www.snagfilms.com/films/title/disconnected . (<location) Jones, Carol Larson. "Online Education." Encyclopedia of Business and Finance . Edited by Burton S. Kaliski, 2nd edition, Volume 2, Macmillan Reference USA, 2007. Jones, Carol Larson. (<author) "Online Education."(<title of source) Encyclopedia of Business and Finance .(<title of container, in italics) Edited by Burton S. Kaliski,(<other contributors) 2nd edition,(<version) Volume 2,(<number) Macmillan Reference USA, (<title of publisher) 2007. (<date of source) Commented [MB1]: This is a sample works cited page. Commented [MB2]: This example shows how an article from a website would be listed on Works Cited. Commented [MB3]: Same citation, broken down to show each component using MLA8. Commented [MB4]: This example shows how a film would be listed on Works Cited. Commented [MB5]: Same citation, broken down to show each component using MLA8. Commented [MB6]: This example shows how a book would be listed on Works Cited. Commented [MB7]: Same citation, broken down to show each component using MLA8.